

This Patient Group Direction (PGD) is intended only for registered healthcare professionals who have been named and authorised by their organisation to practice under it.

Patient Group Direction

for the administration of Nicotine Replacement Therapy (Patches and Oral Products) for the treatment of Smoking Cessation

Summary of NICE / NICE CKS Guidelines for Smoking Cessation

Overview

- Smoking is the leading preventable cause of death
- Nicotine dependence is a chronic relapsing condition
- Pharmacotherapy (varenicline, NRT, bupropion) doubles quit rates compared to placebo

Assessment

- Fagerström score to assess nicotine dependence
- Assess readiness to quit and motivation
- Set a quit date (typically 1-2 weeks from assessment)
- Review previous quit attempts and reasons for relapse
- Screen for contraindications and red flags

Management

- NRT is effective first-line therapy for smoking cessation
- Combination NRT (patch plus short-acting oral product) is more effective than single product
- Combine with structured behavioural support for optimal outcomes
- Follow-up at 2 weeks, 4 weeks, then monthly during treatment

Red Flags

- **Psychiatric history:** Depression, anxiety disorder, psychosis - monitor mood throughout treatment
- **Cardiovascular disease:** Recent MI (within 4 weeks), unstable angina, severe arrhythmias - assess benefit vs risk
- **Skin disorders:** Generalised skin conditions may affect patch absorption

Patient Group Direction

for the supply/administration of

Nicotine patches (e.g. NiQuitin/Nicorette) 7mg, 14mg, 21mg/24-hour

for the treatment of

Smoking Cessation

Healthcare professionals covered and training

	Healthcare professionals allowed to work under this PGD and requirements
Qualifications and Registration	• Pharmacist registered and practicing with the GPhC • Pharmacy technician registered and practicing with the GPhC
Training and assessment	Pharmacists and Pharmacy Technicians must have completed training relevant to this condition to use this PGD. This training will be documented and overseen by the Get Real Health team. • All users must be familiar with the SPC for the products as well as BNF advice and any applicable national guidelines • All users must previously have used PGDs to supply medication • Must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer • All users must have appropriate indemnity in place to cover this service
Further training and responsibilities	• All users must be up to date with CPD requirements and appraisal • All users must be up to date with MHRA and safety alerts with regards to medical products • All users must understand the concepts of capacity and consent and be aware of the Mental Capacity Act 2005.

PGD Indication	Smoking cessation in adults aged 18 years and over who are motivated to quit smoking
Inclusion criteria	Age 18 years and over Motivated to quit smoking and set a quit date Capacity and willingness to provide informed consent
Exclusion criteria	Known hypersensitivity to nicotine or excipients Generalised skin disorders that may affect absorption Non-smokers or occasional smokers
Cautions	Cardiovascular disease: recent MI (within 4 weeks), unstable angina, severe arrhythmias (assess benefit vs risk) Diabetes (monitor blood glucose control; nicotine may affect insulin requirements) Phaeochromocytoma (nicotine may cause catecholamine release) Hepatic/renal impairment (consider close monitoring) Peptic ulcer disease (nicotine may increase gastric acid secretion) Pregnancy (use only if unable to quit without NRT; benefits must outweigh risks)

	Breastfeeding (nicotine passes into breast milk; weigh risks and benefits)
Actions if patient is excluded or declines treatment	Advise on alternative treatment options and how these can be accessed. Document any advice given and the decision reached. Inform or refer to the GP as appropriate.

Details of the medicine

Name, form and strength of medicine	Nicotine patches 7mg, 14mg, 21mg/24-hour (e.g. NiQuitin, Nicorette)
Legal category	P/GSL depending on pack size
Storage	Below 25°C. Protect from moisture and direct sunlight. Keep in original packaging.
Route/method of administration	Transdermal, applied to clean, dry, hairless skin. Rotate application sites daily.
Dose and frequency	Heavy smokers (>10 cigarettes/day): Start 21mg/24-hour patch daily for 6-8 weeks, then 14mg for 2 weeks, then 7mg for 2 weeks Lighter smokers (≤10 cigarettes/day): Start 14mg/24-hour patch daily and step down as above Total course: 8-12 weeks depending on dependence Application: Apply to clean, dry, hairless area (arm or chest). Rotate sites daily to minimize irritation. Press firmly for 10 seconds.
Quantity to be administered and/or supplied	28 patches (4-week supply)
Maximum or minimum treatment period	8-12 weeks. Review at 2 weeks, 4 weeks, then regularly.
Adverse effects	Common: Application site reactions (erythema, burning, itching, swelling); headache; dizziness; insomnia; vivid dreams; palpitations Common: Gastrointestinal disturbance; nausea Uncommon: Rash; urticaria; tachycardia Note: Skin reactions may persist for hours after patch removal

Yellow card reporting	Report suspected adverse effects via https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk and inform the GP as appropriate.
Records to be kept	Record the following information: - that valid informed consent was given - name of individual, address, date of birth and GP

	• name of healthcare practitioner • name and brand of medication • date of supply dose, form and route quantity supplied • advice given, including advice given if excluded or declines treatment • details of any adverse drug reactions and actions taken supplied via PGD Records should be signed and dated. All records should be clear, legible and contemporaneous. Electronic records can be made. A record of all individuals receiving treatment under this PGD should also be kept for audit purposes as follows: • Adults aged 18 years and over - keep records for 8 years • Children aged under 18 years - keep records until the 25th birthday (if the patient was 17 years when treatment was finished, keep records until the 26th birthday)
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Patient information

Written information to be given to patient or carer	Supply the Patient Information Leaflet (PIL) for nicotine patches and/or oral products. Discuss the treatment plan, correct usage technique, and importance of combining with behavioural support.
Follow-up advice to be given to patient or carer	Correct technique is essential: Patches must be applied to clean, dry, hairless skin and sites rotated daily. For gum: chew slowly then park between cheek and gum. For lozenges: dissolve in mouth, do not chew. Combine NRT with behavioural support (smoking cessation counselling, NHS Stop Smoking Services) for best results Combination therapy: Using a patch with short-acting oral product (gum/lozenges) is more effective than either alone Use enough NRT: If you continue to crave cigarettes, you may need higher doses or combination therapy Do not smoke while using NRT: Continued smoking increases nicotine levels and risk of adverse effects Continue NRT for the full 8-12 weeks: Do not stop early even if abstinence is achieved Withdrawal symptoms: Expect cravings and withdrawal symptoms; these usually improve within 2-3 weeks For patches: Remove old patch before applying new one. Dispose of safely (fold with sticky side in). Mild skin redness is normal. For oral products: Do not eat or drink for 15 minutes before and during use. Avoid acidic drinks (coffee, fruit juice) which reduce nicotine absorption. Monitor blood glucose more frequently if diabetic (nicotine may affect insulin requirements)

Valid from date	Expiry date		
1/11/25	31/7/27		

PGD adoption and authorisation by the employer/clinical lead

The employer has ensured that the person using this PGD, has the knowledge and skills to safely provide the service which will encompass the supply or administration of a medication or medicine.

This section must be signed by the superintendent or clinical lead responsible for this service.

Name of superintendent / clinical lead	Job title & name of organisation	Signature	Date
Name of professional group signatory	Job title & name of organisation	Signature	Date

Signed on behalf of Get Real Health

Name	Qualification	Signature	Date
Nitin Shori	Medical Doctor GMC: 6047293		2/11/25
Chris Pilkington	Pharmacist GPhC: 2046322		2/11/25

Change history

Version number	Change details	Date
001	Development & issue of new PGD	1st November 2025

Patient Group Direction

for the supply/administration of

Nicotine oral products (2mg and 4mg lozenges or gum)

for the treatment of

Smoking Cessation

Healthcare professionals covered and training

	Healthcare professionals allowed to work under this PGD and requirements
Qualifications and Registration	• Pharmacist registered and practicing with the GPhC • Pharmacy technician registered and practicing with the GPhC
Training and assessment	Pharmacists and Pharmacy Technicians must have completed training relevant to this condition to use this PGD. This training will be documented and overseen by the Get Real Health team. • All users must be familiar with the SPC for the products as well as BNF advice and any applicable national guidelines • All users must previously have used PGDs to supply medication • Must work in compliance with the SOPs of their own employer • All users must have appropriate indemnity in place to cover this service
Further training and responsibilities	• All users must be up to date with CPD requirements and appraisal • All users must be up to date with MHRA and safety alerts with regards to medical products • All users must understand the concepts of capacity and consent and be aware of the Mental Capacity Act 2005.

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Exclusion criteria	Known hypersensitivity to nicotine or excipients Non-smokers or occasional smokers
Cautions	Cardiovascular disease: recent MI (within 4 weeks), unstable angina, severe arrhythmias (assess benefit vs risk) Diabetes (monitor blood glucose control; nicotine may affect insulin)

	requirements) Phaeochromocytoma (nicotine may cause catecholamine release) Hepatic/renal impairment (consider close monitoring) Peptic ulcer disease (nicotine may increase gastric acid secretion) Oral ulceration or dental work (nicotine products may cause irritation) Pregnancy (use only if unable to quit without NRT; benefits must outweigh risks) Breastfeeding (nicotine passes into breast milk; weigh risks and benefits)
Actions if patient is excluded or declines treatment	Advise on alternative treatment options and how these can be accessed. Document any advice given and the decision reached. Inform or refer to the GP as appropriate.

Details of the medicine

Name, form and strength of medicine	Nicotine lozenges or gum 2mg and 4mg
Legal category	P/GSL
Storage	Below 25°C. Keep in original packaging. Protect from moisture.
Route/method of administration	Oral. Gum: chew slowly, then park between cheek and gum. Lozenges: dissolve slowly in mouth.
Dose and frequency	For those smoking ≤ 20 cigarettes/day: Use 2mg lozenge/gum For those smoking > 20 cigarettes/day: Use 4mg lozenge/gum Initial use: 8-12 pieces/day, reduce gradually over 8-12 weeks Gum technique: Chew slowly, then park between gum and cheek. Repeat chewing when flavour fades. Lozenge technique: Place in mouth and allow to dissolve slowly. Do not chew or swallow whole. Duration: 8-12 weeks total
Quantity to be administered and/or supplied	Up to 4-week supply (maximum 120 pieces depending on daily use)
Maximum or minimum treatment period	8-12 weeks. Review at 2 weeks, 4 weeks, then regularly.
Adverse effects	Common: Mouth and throat irritation; hiccups; gastrointestinal discomfort; jaw ache (gum); headache; nausea Uncommon: Palpitations; tachycardia Note: Oral symptoms usually diminish with continued use

Yellow card reporting	Report suspected adverse effects via https://yellowcard.mhra.gov.uk and inform the GP as appropriate.
Records to be kept	Record the following information: • that valid informed consent was given • name of individual, address, date of birth and GP • name of healthcare practitioner • name and brand of medication • date of supply dose, form and route quantity supplied • advice given, including advice given if excluded or declines treatment • details of any adverse drug reactions and actions taken supplied via PGD Records should be signed and dated. All records should be clear, legible and contemporaneous. Electronic records can be made. A record of all individuals receiving treatment under this PGD should also be kept for audit purposes as follows: • Adults aged 18 years and over - keep records for 8 years • Children aged under 18 years - keep records until the 25th birthday (if the patient was 17 years when treatment was finished, keep records until the 26th birthday)

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Follow-up advice to be given to patient or carer	Correct technique is essential: Patches must be applied to clean, dry, hairless skin and sites rotated daily. For gum: chew slowly then park between cheek and gum. For lozenges: dissolve in mouth, do not chew. Combine NRT with behavioural support (smoking cessation counselling, NHS Stop Smoking Services) for best results Combination therapy: Using a patch with short-acting oral product (gum/lozenges) is more effective than either alone Use enough NRT: If you continue to crave cigarettes, you may need higher doses or combination therapy Do not smoke while using NRT: Continued smoking increases nicotine levels and risk of adverse effects Continue NRT for the full 8-12 weeks: Do not stop early even if abstinence is achieved Withdrawal symptoms: Expect cravings and withdrawal symptoms; these usually improve within 2-3 weeks

	For patches: Remove old patch before applying new one. Dispose of safely (fold with sticky side in). Mild skin redness is normal. For oral products: Do not eat or drink for 15 minutes before and during use. Avoid acidic drinks (coffee, fruit juice) which reduce nicotine absorption. Monitor blood glucose more frequently if diabetic (nicotine may affect insulin requirements) Avoid driving or operating machinery if experiencing dizziness Cardiovascular symptoms: Seek immediate medical attention if experiencing chest pain, palpitations, or shortness of breath Report severe skin reactions or oral irritation to your healthcare provider Inform healthcare provider immediately if pregnant or planning pregnancy Attend follow-up appointments at 2 weeks, 4 weeks, and monthly to monitor progress
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Key references

- NICE Medicines Practice Guideline 2 (MPG2): Patient Group Directions. Published March 2017 <https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mg2>
- NICE MPG2 Patient group directions: competency framework for health professionals using patient group directions. Updated March 2017 <https://www.nice.org.uk/guidance/mpg2/resources>
- NICE CKS Guidance: Smoking Cessation
- British National Formulary (BNF) Key information on the selection, prescribing, dispensing and administration of medicines

Agreement to practise by the Registered Healthcare Professional

By signing this PGD you are confirming that you agree to its contents and that you will work within it. PGDs do not remove inherent professional obligations or accountability. It is the responsibility of each healthcare professional to practise only within the bounds of their own competence and professional code of conduct.

Name and address of pharmacy premises / clinic premises to which this PGD relates			
Name of healthcare professional	Job title	Registration number	Signature

Valid from date	Expiry date		
1/11/25	31/7/27		

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